

Linux On A Stick

Portable Linux Distributions are compact operating systems meant for users who would like to carry their operating systems along to work or wherever they need to go. They need to be as feature-packed as possible without going overboard on the resources and storage space front.

Damn Small Linux 3.4

Site: www.damnsmalllinux.org

Size: 49 MB

Damn Small Linux (DSL) is what first comes to mind when you think of portable, compact Linux distributions. The Live CD loads up without any issues into a Fluxbox-powered interface. You can switch to the jwm window manager if you don't like Fluxbox, but it isn't as nice looking. The interface is minimal and clean. A transparent panel on the right of the Desktop shows you statistics for system resources, network speeds, and so on. This adds to the geek factor that most people generally associate with Linux.



A very compact distribution with the bare necessities

Functionality-wise, there's a lot stuffed into DSL, considering it's just short of 50 MB. There's almost everything from browsers like Firefox to PDF readers to the remote access programs Rdesktop and VNCViewer. There's even a command-line-based CD/DVD burning software, cdw. Instant messengers are limited—there are text-based AIM, IRC, and Jabber clients, but nothing for the more commonly used MSN or Yahoo!. A utility called DSL Control Panel allows you to change settings and turn services on and off quickly using buttons on the interface.

As for entertainment, audio playback shouldn't be a problem with xmms around. A video player could have been included, though, without sacrificing much on space. Moving on to games, you'll only find card games in DSL—other than a Tetris game here and there. Fortunately, extensions can be added to Damn Small Linux through the Internet using a program called MyDSL Extension Browser. You can also install extensions downloaded to the local drive using the same application.

Let us put it this way—Damn Small Linux is pretty *damn* small as its name suggests, and it packs in loads of features despite its constraints. It is the geek's Swiss Knife, and can be carried about on portable USB drives. Its compact size is what makes it stand out, and also what cripples it by not letting it be a complete Desktop. The lack of a video player or even a proper word processor is proof of this. Still, you can do almost everything you would on a Desktop with DSL. It's an adequately functional Desktop replacement for those who travel a lot.

SLAX Standard Edition 5.1.8.1

Site: www.slax.org

Size: 192 MB

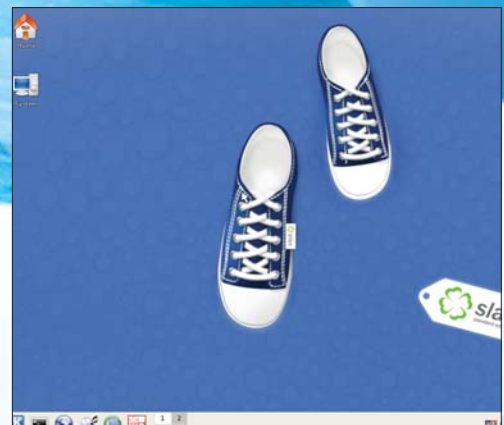
At 192 MB, SLAX doesn't come close to Damn Small Linux in terms of portability, but with 2 GB USB Drives available for under Rs 1,000, portable disk space isn't an issue any longer. Also, at 192 MB, it has many more software packages than DSL does.

The Live CD boots into the console, after which you are required to enter the root username and password. You then need to type `startx` to load the X Window System—this could all have been automated, but that tiny bit of disappointment ends here. SLAX looks a lot better than DSL—much more like a proper Desktop operating system.

The first thing you notice when you go through the menus is they seem to have everything made for KDE in it. That means no Firefox, no Abiword, no xmms, nothing. Those who love KDE shouldn't have any problem, but GNOME fans might find it a little hard to digest.

That aside, the distribution has components out of KOffice for word processing, spreadsheets and presentation. Konqueror automatically becomes your browser. Unlike with DSL, you can play video—they've included a media player called Kplayer (it comes pre-installed).

SLAX doesn't allow you to install programs, but there are ways to configure the ISO to add modules. The command-line RPM (Red Hat Package Manager, though the term is rarely used) module is



A complete Desktop in a compact package

